

1. The first step is to identify the problem or question that needs to be answered. This involves understanding the context and the specific requirements of the task.

[illegible]

THE LOST WOMAN

OF SAN NICOLAS ISLAND

A ROMANCE OF CALIFORNIA PIONEER DAYS



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According to the best authorities the Island of San Nicolas, off the coast of Santa Barbara, and also the other islands in that vicinity, were once thickly populated; in fact, the large piles of shells, bones and other refuse still found on them prove that fact without other evidence.

From the statement made by George Nidever, who came to this Coast in 1851, it seems that the Alaska Indians were in the habit of making periodical visits to these islands for otter and other skins.

They were well supplied with fire-arms and were dangerous foes even to the white man, and much more so to the natives who had only stony implements of warfare.

In 1824 a number of these Indians were left on the San Nicolas Island by a Russian vessel.

In a quarrel that ensued with the native population they took possession of all the native women, after having first killed every man and male child on the island.

When the season of hunting was over they left the island, abandoning the women to their fate.

This circumstance having come to the knowledge of the padres of the Mission San Gabriel they employed Isaac J. Sparks and Lewis T. Burton, American hunters and trappers, to remove the women.

Having succeeded in getting the women together on the beach ready for



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embarking one of them, made signs that her child had been left behind, where-upon she was allowed to go back and get it. She was gone some time when a strong wind springing up, they did not dare wait longer for her, fearing for the safety of the schooner.

The water, which is quite shoal about the island, becomes exceedingly rough in a storm, and there is no harbor of any kind that would afford shelter in a gale.

The schooner reached San Pedro in safety, and the women were taken to the Mission.

It was the intention of the captain of the schooner to return for the woman who had been left on the island, but being obliged to first make a trip to San Francisco the schooner was wrecked near the Golden Gate, and all hands lost.

There was at that time no craft of any kind in Santa Barbara larger than an Indian canoe and the boats of the other hunters on the coast, and none cared to attempt the passage of the channel in an open boat.

It soon became known throughout the

Coast that an Indian woman had been left helpless on the island, but no attempt was made to rescue her, and as the years passed by all thought she had perished.

In the year 1851 George Nidever and Thomas Jeffries had occasion to visit San Nicolas, and found signs that led them to believe that the woman still survived.

Soon after reaching the island they found the footprints of a human being, that, in all probability, had been made during the previous rainy season.

They were sunk quite deep in the ground, that was now hard and dry. They were distinctly defined and from their size they concluded they were those of a woman.

They also discovered three small circular inclosures about 200 yards back from the beach, something like a mile apart, and situated on slightly rising ground.

Near the huts or inclosures were stakes of drift wood stuck in the ground, and suspended upon them at a height of five or six feet were pieces of dried blubber.

Nidever and Jeffries intended to make a thorough search for the woman, but fearing a storm they hastened to make the mainland.

In the winter of 1852 Nidever made a second trip to the island, accompanied by the hunter Charles Brown.

After searching around for some time and finding no trace of her they concluded that the wild dogs that infested the island must have eaten her. Nidever, however, discovered in the crotch of a small tree a basket, and upon throwing off the piece of seal skin that covered it he found, carefully laid together, a dress made of shag skins cut in square pieces, a rope made of sinew and several smaller articles, such as abalone fish hooks, bone needles, etc.

Brown proposed replacing the articles and returning the basket to the tree where they had found it, but Nidever scattered the articles on the ground saying that if upon their return they found them replaced in the basket, it would be positive evidence of the wo-

man's existence.

For the next few days the two men were busy hunting others, and on about the fourth or fifth day a southeast wind began to blow, which soon increased to a gale, and it was with difficulty that they managed to reach San Miguel Island.

In July, 1851, Nidver and a crew consisting of Brown and four Mission Indians made another trip to the island, with the intention of making a thorough and final search for the lost woman.

On reaching the island the party hunted in different directions without success until Brown reached the highest point on the island, when he caught sight of a small black object a long distance off that seemed to be moving. It looked at first glance very much like a crow.

Walking toward it, he soon saw it was the Indian woman.

She was seated in an inclosure, so that her head and shoulders were barely visible above it.

As he approached her two or three dogs that were close to her began growling.

Without looking in the direction of Brown the woman gave a yell and the dogs disappeared.

Brown halted within a few yards of the woman, and at once began to signal to the rest of the party by placing his hat upon the ramrod of his gun and raising and lowering it.

He succeeded in attracting their attention, and they came towards him.

In the meantime Brown had an opportunity of observing the woman.

She was seated cross-legged on some grass that covered the inclosure, and which no doubt served as a bed.

Her only dress was a kind of gown leaving her neck and shoulders bare, and long enough when she stood up to reach to her ankles.

It was made of shagskin cut in squares and sewed together, the leathers pointed downward. Her head had no covering save a thick mass of matted hair of a yellowish brown color, the strange hue probably resulting from exposure to sun and rain. She was engaged in stripping blubber from a piece of sealskin, which she held across her knee, using in the operation a rude knife made of a piece of iron hoop.

Within the enclosure was a smoldering fire, and without a large pile of bones and another of bones, which would indicate that this had been her abode for a long time.

From the time Brown first arrived within hearing distance she kept up a continued talking to herself, occasionally shading her eyes with her hand and gazing steadily at the men who were seen walking around on the flat below. She was evidently much interested in their movements.

As the men came nearer Brown motioned them to spread out, so as to prevent her escape if she were disposed to attempt it.

Just before the men reached her camp Brown, who had not yet been seen by her, came around in front.

To his great surprise, she received him with much dignity and politeness, bowing and smiling with ease and self-possession.

As fast as the other members of the party came up she ~~asked~~ them in the same way, all the time asking, although not a word of hers ~~could be~~ understood, and the Indian spoke several dialects.

Nilever made signs for her to accompany them to the schooner. But she seemed unable to comprehend them until he intimated that she must gather up all her tools, when she set about the work with great alacrity, and commenced putting them in a large basket, such as was in general use among the Indians of the coast.

She seemed desirous of preserving everything that would sustain life, thus indicating the sad experiences of her eighteen years of solitude.

When they reached the vessel she sought the vicinity of the stove, which indicated more of her bitter experiences on the island.

Brown made her a petticoat out of some bed ticking, with which she was much pleased, continually calling attention to it.

On the trip to Santa Barbara a furious gale arose, which threatened to engulf the little vessel. The woman

made signs that she could allay the wind, and, kneeling down, facing the quarter from whence the wind blew, she commenced making incantations or prayers.

When the wind finally abated she pointed in triumph to a patch of clear sky, as much as to say, "See what I did!"

On reaching Santa Barbara, it is doubtful whether pleasure or wonder predominated in her mind.

An ox team with a Spanish cart passed on the sand. The yoke was tied the animals to each other and to the cart, the uncouth wheels, with their rotary motion, seemed incessantly wonderful, delightful and ludicrous to her.

She laughed, talked and gesticulated all at once.

She was taken to Nido's house, where she was tenderly cared for by his wife.

The story soon spread that the lost woman of San Nicolas had been found.

The possibility of there being a woman living alone on a desert island in the ocean with only wild animals for companions had been discussed in many households, and was a subject of intense interest.

Hundreds flocked to Nido's house. Among others came Fathers Martinez, Sanchez and Jimeno. Although familiar with all the dialects of the coast, not a word of her language could they understand. Indians from Santa Ynez, Los Angeles and other parts were brought, with no better success. Not one of them understood even a word of her language.

She soon became very expert at conversing by signs, however, and continued to tell portions of her story, as

that but little uncertainty attended her narrative.

She related that when she went back after her child she wandered a long time without finding it, that when she concluded that the wolf had eaten her child she lay down and cried a long time and became so weak that she could not walk, and finally recovered so that she could get around, and began to eat.

She had often seen vessels out on the sea, but none of them ever came to take her away.

She finally became reconciled to her fate, and commenced her routine of life, which was to be varied only by hunger, thirst, cold and fights with animals for nearly a score of years.

She was received with the utmost kindness. Almost at once she made her a present of money and some trinkets, which, however, she immediately gave to her friends, and the children who came to see her.

Nidever's family became much attached to her, and Nidever several times refused large sums which were offered to him to have her exhibited to the public in San Francisco.

She was estimated to be about 50 years old at the time she was recovered.

She was like a child in every respect, with no control over her appetite, being exceedingly fond of meat, which she would eat at all hours. This caused a dysentery, which, despite of careful nursing and attention, terminated fatally in about four weeks.

She was buried by the padres, her funeral being attended by an immense concourse of people, and most of her trinkets, including the wonderful feather dress, were taken to Home.